EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

When Is Teshuvah Not Enough?

Given Monday 10 February 2025 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 5:6-7

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 5 (Merits and Demerits), Chapter 6 and the first part of Chapter 7

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 10 February 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Recap: The Fifth Essay So Far

The Rabbi opened by reviewing the three main things the essay has taught up to now.

1. **Mitzvot and aveirot leave an impression.** Our *zechuyot* and *chovot* make an impress on the soul and on our identity, and **הקדוש ברוך הוא remembers it all**.
2. **Ten categories of people.** He ran through them once more:

#	Name	Who he is
1	**צדיק**	A majority of mitzvot
2	**רשע**	A majority of aveirot
3	**עובד**	The obedient person, committed to one particular mitzvah
4	**ממרה**	The disobedient person, who wilfully neglects one mitzvah he has no interest in keeping
5	**שלם**	The complete person, who does everything
6	**מקצר**	Negligent in the *mitzvot aseh*, the positive commandments
7	**חוטא**	Transgresses negative prohibitions, but not the most severe ones
8	**מזיד**	The rebellious person, who violates prohibitions carrying the death penalty or *karet*
9	**כופר**	The denier: one who serves *avodah zarah*, denies God's existence, or has doubts. All three fall under "denier"
10	**שב**	The penitent

Last week covered the tenth category: the **four aspects of teshuvah**, which Saadia was the very first to enumerate, and which all the Rishonim after him took up, with the same idea and

the same verses. Saadia also gave advice on how to keep one's resolve (writing and meditating on poems about the futility of human life) and listed things that help teshuvah: **tefillah, tzedakah, and teaching others the ways of Hashem**.

1. **Theodicy.** Earlier chapters gave Saadia's explanation of why the righteous suffer and the wicked seem to prosper.

"Now we have three remaining chapters which are easier chapters to get through. There aren't great fundamental things there. They're more lists of things." The plan: a chapter and a half tonight, and the remaining chapter and a half next week.

Chapter 6: A Chapter of Lists

"Remember we've said how Saadia loves lists, very often exhaustive lists." Chapter 6 is a string of side points that grow out of the discussion of teshuvah in Chapter 5. By the end of the shiur the Rabbi counted seven of them.

Point 1: Seven things that prevent tefillah

In Chapter 5 Saadia said that tefillah helps teshuvah. So he digresses to explain when tefillah does **not** work. Since prayer is an essential part of teshuvah, the message is: make sure you do not fall into any of these seven categories, "so that your tefillah will not be worthless and your teshuvah will be effective."

Of the seven, the recording preserves the Rabbi's discussion of the first two.

1. When the decree has been sealed. Sometimes Hashem passes an edict that cannot be changed. Moshe prayed to enter the Land, and the Chachamim say he prayed 515 times, the numerical value of **ואתחנן**. The answer was, in effect, "that's it, there's nothing more to talk about." Sometimes, through no fault of your own, the decree has been passed, "and there's nothing you can do even with the greatest of tefillah, and we have to understand that."

2. Prayer without concentration. Saadia quotes Tehillim 78: **ויפתוהו בפיהם ובלשונם יכזבו לו ולבם לא נכון עמו**. They tried to seduce Hashem with their lips, but their heart was not with Him, and so the prayer was not accepted.

The Rabbi added a caveat from the **Gemara in Ta'anit 8a**. The Gemara says a person's prayer is only accepted if he prays with full attention and sincerity, and quotes the same verse. But the very next verse says **והוא רחום יכפר עון**, the merciful One still forgives, which seems to say that even without intent you are forgiven. The Gemara answers: in a congregation, even without full intent, prayer is still somewhat effective. When Saadia says prayer without *kavanah* is worth nothing, that applies to an individual praying alone. "So sitting and reading lots of things and not understanding what you're reading doesn't have much value here."

Point 2: Three things that block teshuvah

Saadia now returns to teshuvah itself. The Rabbi reminded those who came to the Tuesday night shiurim on **Rambam Hilchot Teshuvah**: in Chapter 4 the Rambam lists **24 things** that impede teshuvah, quoting the **Rif**, some more severe than others. Saadia is again the first to list such impediments, and he gives **only three**. "This was then developed and ended up by the Rambam's time to 24." All sins can be forgiven aside from these three:

1. Being a bad influence on others. Either philosophically, teaching people the wrong ideas, or practically, giving wrong *psakim*. This cannot be rectified, because the effect is already out of your hands: "how can you remedy that when you've told many people the wrong thing?" Saadia brings the verse **משגה ישרים בדרך רע**, one who leads the upright astray onto an evil path. The same verse ends that the innocent "will still inherit goodness": those who followed in sincerity, thinking they were doing right, are not blamed. The Rambam says the same of one who sins and causes the public to sin, as with the idols set up in public places. "The greater the influence, the more a person needs to be careful that he doesn't lead them down the wrong path."

2. Defaming someone. This too cannot be rectified. The Rabbi brought the halachah, cited by the **Rema in the Shulchan Aruch**, in the laws of asking forgiveness. Normally, if someone asks you sincerely and genuinely, you have to forgive. But there is one sin you do not have to forgive: public defamation. Even if he asks three times, brings different people each time and is sincere, there is no obligation. "You stole money from me, give the money back, we can rectify that. You hurt me, you hit me, you can rectify that. But if you defame me, how are we going to do that? How are we going to get those words back?"

3. Having forbidden property in your possession. You can do teshuvah, but while the stolen item is still with you, it does not work. Saadia brings the verse **חבל ישיב רשע גזלה ישלם**: the wicked man should return what he has taken, and then he will walk in the ways of life. If the victim has died, return it to his estate; if that is impossible, make it *hefker*. The **Rambam adds** another possibility: donate it to public funds, so that it benefits the community rather than whoever happens to pick it up. "Don't do this in the first instance. This is when you've got no alternative."

Questions on restitution

Q: If I stole something and used it, can I rectify it by returning it and paying for the benefit?

Most certainly. In fact, halachically, simply returning it is enough. If your use did not devalue it, you do not even have to pay for the use; it was wrong, but there is no financial liability. If you did devalue it, you return it and pay for the loss in value.

Q: What if I changed the object into something new?

Then **שינוי קונה**: the change acquires it, and it now belongs to you. But you must pay the value of the original and ask for *mechilah*. Sometimes two changes are needed, a change in the thing itself and a change in its name, before it becomes yours according to everyone. The principle is like the idea in English law of putting the person back in his original position. There are two elements: the material restitution, and the *mechilah*. "When you have the two together, then you can ask me" for forgiveness, not before.

Point 3: Four sins that bring consequences even after teshuvah

"This is something really interesting, which you probably never heard before. This is the first time I've ever seen it when I saw it inside... To the best of my knowledge, it's his own idea, and it's not really replicated in later authorities."

Saadia says there are certain sins for which teshuvah works, yet you will still have to suffer something in this world. He reads the Torah's phrase **לא ינקה**, "he will not be absolved," to mean exactly this: teshuvah rectifies your place in the world to come, but some consequence will come in this world. The four:

1. **Swearing in vain. כי לא ינקה ה' את אשר ישא את שמו לשוא.** (The Rabbi paused over the text: the older editions have the word **את**, matching the verse, which reassured him that nothing was missing.)
2. **Murder.** The verse speaks of blood that "will not be cleansed."
3. **Adultery.** "He will not be absolved."
4. **Perjury.** A false witness, one who lies in court, "will not be absolved."

The Rabbi first named the first item as perjury and then corrected himself: the first is swearing in vain and the fourth is perjury.

Is there a source? The **Talmud Yerushalmi** at the beginning of **Pe'ah** says something slightly similar. Just as the Mishnah lists things whose fruits you enjoy in this world while the principal remains for the next, the Yerushalmi lists sins that are punished in this world with something remaining for the next. Two of the four in that list match Saadia's, adultery and murder; for the other two Saadia has perjury and swearing in vain. But the Rabbi did not think it really proves Saadia's point. The Yerushalmi says that **if you don't do teshuvah**, you will suffer in both worlds. "It doesn't say that if I do full teshuvah that I'm going to suffer in this world, right? So that's why I find this a very interesting paragraph."

Point 4: Sins against another person

If you have hurt someone, abused them or struck them, teshuvah alone does not work. It depends on the forgiveness of the person you hurt. Saadia brings Yosef's brothers, who said **אנא שא נא**, "please forgive." You must ask **three times**.

If he has died before you could ask, Saadia says you must ask **in the presence of ten people, three times**. The Rabbi found this very interesting, because the Gemara and the Poskim do not say it in this form. The halachah says to take ten people and ask forgiveness; it does not say three times. Why ten? The Rishonim explain it from how one asks a living person: first you ask him privately, once. If he says no, you bring three people and ask again; if no, another three; if no, another three. "Think about it: you got him and three, three, three is nine, is ten." Saadia, however, requires both: ten people and three times. Later it became customary to go to the grave, "but really in the presence of ten people suffices."

Point 5: Three mitzvot rewarded in this world

Even a person who ends up denying God and committing the worst sins will receive some reward in this world if he has done any of these, because the Torah promises long life for them:

1. **Honouring parents.**
2. **Sending away the mother bird.** Saadia reads this broadly, "as being a general concept of welfare, of animal welfare, not a specific thing of the bird and the chicken."
3. **Honesty in business**: **אבן שלמה וצדק**, a whole and honest weight, with the promise of long days.

A fourth case: when good has been decreed for someone, as with **Yehu**, who was promised that four generations of his descendants would sit on the throne, even though he and his children sinned.

The Gemara's problem. Classically, only two mitzvot are mentioned with long life, *kibbud av va'em* and *shiluach haken*, although Saadia is "entirely right" that the Torah also says it of honest weights. The famous Gemara tells of a man whose father told him to climb a ladder and send away the mother bird. He was doing both mitzvot at once, and he fell and died. Because of this, the Gemara concludes that there is no real reward in this world: "long life" means life in the world that is eternally long. The **Rambam** understands it the same way.

Saadia, as so often, stays committed to the verse. The main meaning may be what the Chachamim say, long life in the world to come, "but nonetheless, there still is something here... and therefore it must be that in this world you will receive something."

Q: Doesn't charity come into it?

The verse says **צדקה תציל ממות**, charity saves from death. That means it saves you from a particular instance of death. "Doesn't mean it prolongs your life... It's not the same as you'll have long days." It is a minor point; the big point is that for these three, there has to be some manifestation of reward in this world.

Point 6: Three sins the Torah calls "a sin in you"

Saadia adds, in parentheses: although there are four sins whose consequences must be felt in this world, do not think there are more. For three sins the Torah says **והיה בך חטא**, "it will be a sin in you": **delaying vows**, **refusing to lend to a poor person**, and **not paying employees on time**. Even so, full teshuvah works for them, and you will not suffer any consequence.

Point 7: Five levels of teshuvah

Saadia gives five levels, in descending order. (The Rambam has three.)

1. **The same capability.** You repent in exactly the same circumstances in which you sinned, and you hold back.
2. **Less capability.** You repent when the circumstances are not the same.
3. **When threatened.**
4. **When threatened and the punishment has begun.**
5. **As you die.**

Even teshuvah at the time of death is still considered teshuvah. This, says Saadia, is why it is customary at a deathbed to tell the dying person to say **ותהא מיתתי כפרה על כל עונותי**, let my death be an atonement for all my sins. The Rabbi noted that this custom, found in the Siddurim, is a later idea, though the Gemara does say that death atones.

He added a practical word. We do this as close to death as possible, so that the person is conscious of it before he dies, but "it doesn't have to be the last second." He has seen people go every hour to make sure it is said just as the person dies. "No point in that. Once the person can no longer sin, is in palliative care, then that's it. You do it once and finished."

Summary of Chapter 6

#	Point
1	Seven things that prevent tefillah being accepted
2	Three things that block teshuvah: misleading others, defamation, holding stolen property
3	Four sins with a consequence in this world even after full teshuvah: swearing in vain, murder, adultery, perjury
4	Sins against others depend on the victim's forgiveness; if he has died, ask three times before ten people
5	Three mitzvot guaranteed some reward in this world: honouring parents, animal welfare, honesty in business
6	Three sins called "a sin in you" that full teshuvah still clears: delaying vows, not lending to the poor, late wages
7	Five levels of teshuvah, down to teshuvah at death

"Again, you see Saadia loves the list. All of them have got lists."

Chapter 7, Part 1: The Eleventh Category, the Beinoni

Chapter 7 has two parts. The first introduces an **eleventh** category; the second gives **eleven contrasts** in the weight of mitzvot, to be done next week.

The eleventh category is the **בינוני**, the "equal" person: one whose sins and merits are equal in number. Saadia then writes six words about him that can be read in two ways, and "there's a huge difference" between them.

Two readings of one line

- **Reading 1:** "If he is found to receive the mercy of God, he will be counted with the righteous." The emphasis is on Hashem's compassion.
- **Reading 2:** "If such a person can be found, he will receive compassion and be counted with the tzaddikim." The emphasis is on how rare he is.

Why it matters: the Rambam's beinoni

When the class learned the Rambam, they saw that the Rambam rejects the idea of someone who is exactly fifty-fifty, because the statistical chance of finding such a person, taking into account everything about him, is almost nil: "maybe one person in seven and eight billion people." Yet the Gemara has a great deal to say about the beinoni and how Hashem's kindness tips him toward the tzaddikim.

So for the Rambam, the beinoni is not a fifty-fifty tally of mitzvot. "It's about your identity, what kind of person you are, and this is why he writes the majority of us are beinonim." We live our lives in contradiction, with some good values and some bad values, sometimes more of one,

sometimes more of the other. That is very common, which is why the Gemara needs to tell us so much about the beinoni.

If Saadia agrees, then he must be read the first way: Hashem has mercy and counts this person among the tzaddikim. He would not write "if he can be found" about something so common. But some read Saadia the second way, as understanding the beinoni statistically: an exact fifty-fifty, and **if** you can find such a person, he will receive mercy. "This line really is a crucial line to understand Saadia's philosophy with the beinoni... That's open for discussion."

The Rabbi's own leaning: "I much more understand the idea of it being a more holistic identity approach." Either way, Saadia's point is the same. Whether you are fifty-fifty in your identity or in your actions, Hashem's kindness counts you among the tzaddikim.

Mercy is not an attribute

Saadia adds a reminder of what the class learned in the early essays of the book. When we speak of Hashem's mercy, we do not mean that mercy is an attribute of God. "Not possible... there's no attributes to Him." Rather, it is described in relation to us, the creatures: it is one of the ways in which Hashem appears to us as compassionate. And that compassion is that He places us among the tzaddikim even though we are fifty-fifty.

Three places where Hashem's mercy appears

1. **He accepts our teshuvah**, our return to Him.
2. **He listens to our prayers** in deep pain, in the most difficult times of despair.
3. **He places the beinoni in the category of the righteous.** This is what is meant by **מטה כלפי חסד**: He tilts toward kindness.

"At the end of the day, there are only two categories: tzaddik and rasha. There's no third category." The beinoni does not remain a category of his own. Hashem's kindness is that if you are fifty-fifty, He puts you with the righteous.

Summary

1. **Tefillah has limits.** It cannot overturn a sealed decree, as Moshe's 515 prayers show, and prayer without *kavanah* is of little worth for an individual, though a congregation's prayer still helps (Ta'anit 8a).
2. **Three things block teshuvah**: leading others astray, public defamation, and keeping stolen property. Saadia lists three; by the Rambam's time the list had grown to 24.
3. **Restitution plus mechilah** is the formula for wrongs against others.
4. **Saadia's own chiddush**: four sins (swearing in vain, murder, adultery, perjury) carry a consequence in this world even after full teshuvah. The Yerushalmi in Pe'ah is similar but speaks only of one who has not repented.
5. **Wrongs against others** need the victim's forgiveness; after his death, Saadia requires asking three times before ten people.
6. **Three mitzvot carry reward in this world.** Saadia insists on the plain sense of "long days," against the Gemara's and the Rambam's reading of eternal life.
7. **Five levels of teshuvah**, down to "let my death be an atonement."

8. **The beinoni** is counted with the tzaddikim. Whether he is a rare statistical fifty-fifty or, as the Rambam and the Rabbi prefer, the common person of mixed identity, Hashem tilts toward kindness.

Coming Up

Next week the class will finish the rest of Chapter 7, the **eleven contrasts in the weight of deeds**, and Chapter 8, "eleven really random… separate things," closing the essay with points about thoughts and other matters. In two weeks' time: **Essay 6, on the soul**, "a very interesting and deep essay."

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